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Culture (OWC): [Chagga \(FN04\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: None

Coverage Date: 1900-1940

Place Coverage: Chagga, Tanzania

Section Title(S): C

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If it is true that the play-group has its own peculiar material outfit and follows its independent traditions, it is necessary to examine more closely its social organization and its 'educational' effects. As in mimicry play, the child group anticipates adult life, and through the manufacture of toys creates its own outfit, so through competitive games it carries out a selective process which determines the status of the individual. For the continuous testing of physical adaptability, mental alertness, and social qualities going on in the play-group leads to the intimidation and subjection of those who fail, while those that are successful are received as equals and those of exceptional skill assume leading positions.

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The novices of the play-group have to undergo a severe introductory training in the form of practical jokes. Small boys are advised not to grasp nettles boldly and touching them gingerly are, of course, stung. A species of bird called *kilepuru*, they are told by the experienced boys, can be caught if approached with closed eyes. The novice gropes about for one and after some fumbling opens his eyes. The birds are gone and he is mocked: 'Why on earth did you open your eyes!' An older boy pinches a youngster and, admitting his deed, says: 'I'll let you have some of my snuff, only stop crying!' Getting hold of the child's thumb and index finger, he moves them towards the sufferer's nose and quickly makes the fingers nip it. Or the old hand tells the novice: 'Do you know that there is an eye under the thumb-nail?' He takes a thorn and pushes it under the nail so that the novice writhes with pain. ■ 265 'It's the eye that pains!' he is told. Or a 'fresher' is invited by an older herds-boy to stand on his outstretched legs when he sits down, and then to jump off at a given sign. At the moment of jumping the sitting boy pushes his legs upwards so that the other loses his balance. When the smaller boys fall asleep on the pasture, they later find their legs tied with lianas or attached to a log of wood.

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Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.eduIssues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



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